Themes (AO1)

Responsibility

Mr Birling's sense of responsibility stops at his business and he does not understand or appreciate the value of social or community responsibility. The inspector wanted each member of the family to share the responsibility of Eva's death; he tells them, **"each of you helped to kill her.** However, his final speech is aimed not only at the characters on stage, but at the audience too especially when he says, '**One Eva Smith has gone- but there are millions and millions and millions of Eva Smiths and John Smiths still left with us'**, Through Eva's death, Priestley promotes collective responsibility, demonstrating that everyone is society is linked, in the same way that all the characters are linked to Eva Smith. Priestley promotes the idea that everyone is a part of **"one body"** and have collective responsibility, as the Inspector sees society as more important than individual interests The inspector challenges the values of individualism. Priestly wanted the characters to develop a social conscience and to embrace collective responsibility. He reveals the consequences of individualism when he claims that **"if men will not learn that lesson, when they will be taught it in fire and blood and anguish."** In the play, both Sheila and Eric develop a social conscience and have learnt that they need to be accountable for their actions. In this way, Priestley indicates that that they have embodied the values of the Inspector and have become more socially responsible. Priestley also suggests through Mr and Mrs Birling and Gerald Croft, that many people in society are entrenched in their individualistic and capitalist belief system and are only concerned with personal responsibility as indicated in '**a man has to mind his own business and look after himself'**

The Generation Gap

The play demonstrates the contrast between the older and younger generations. Sheila, Eric and Eva represent the huge generation gap in the play. The ideas of the parents are locked in the old way of thinking where children need to follow in the footsteps of their parents in an unquestioning way. They would like to think that they can control their children's thinking. They have little sympathy for Eva Smith and are only sorry that she has died because it could impact on their lives.

It is clear that the younger generation are different by the end of the play. They are no longer controlled by their parents and their ideas. While Mr and Mrs Birling refuse to accept responsibility for their conduct and actions towards Eva Smith, their children are taking responsibility and show remorse for their actions. They express sympathy for the strikers in Act 1 and they also show greater sympathy for Eva Smith. Through this, Priestley suggests hope for the future of Britain where people and governments are more socially